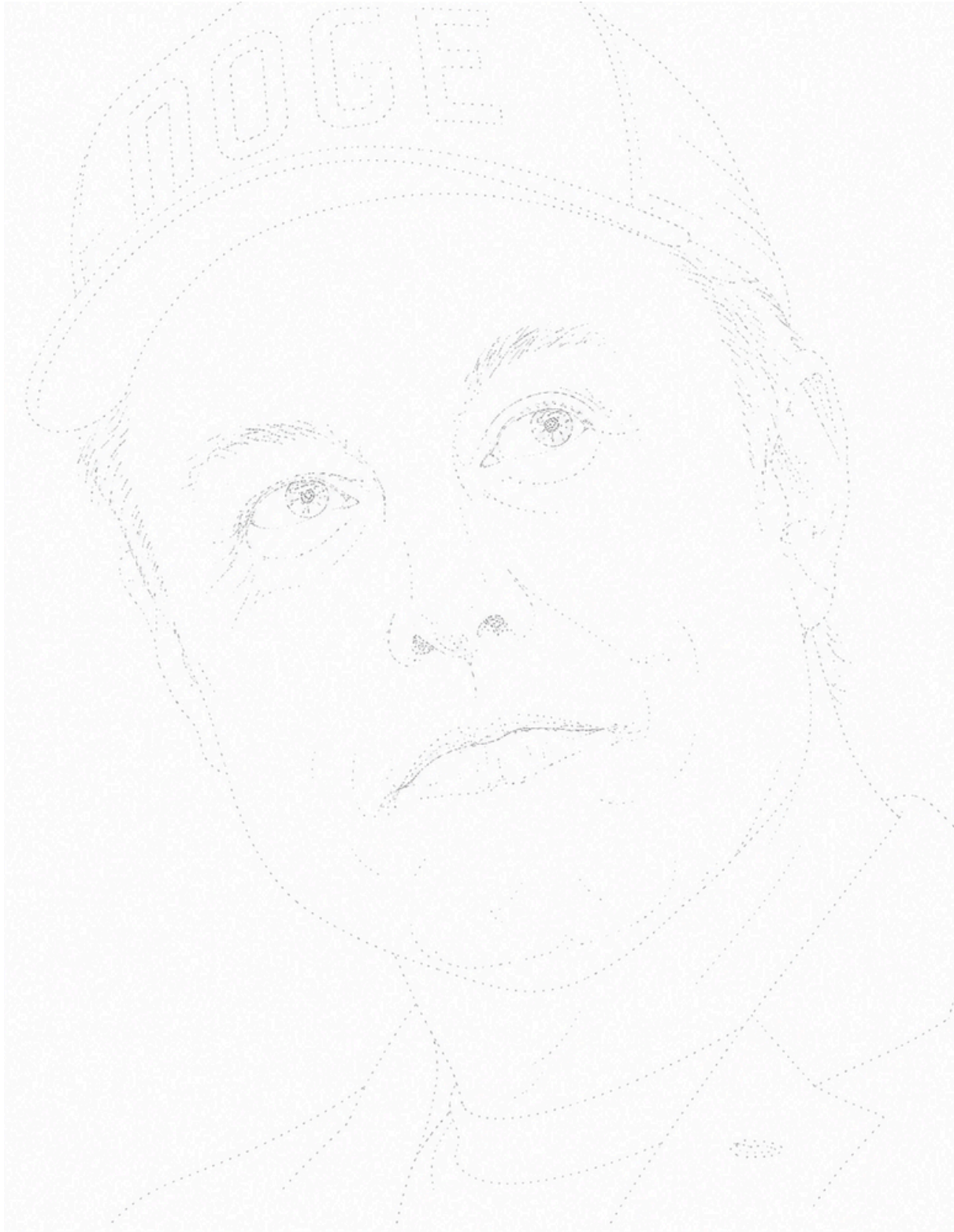


Line art — print at A4, 100% scale. Personal practice use.



Portrait Guide #022

Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10–14 hours

Subject A male-presenting person wearing a dark cap that covers most of the hair, with a clean-shaven face, calm neutral expression, and warm golden-olive medium-deep skin tone.

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is *doing*, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils — Set of 24, Portrait Colors — the skin colors this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step or garment names a number you don't have, swatch with whatever you like or close.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. **No solvent** — every blend in this guide is dry.

• COLOR PALETTE



Black

PC935

Near-black neutral garment and deepest core shadows; darkest focal accents (upper lash line, pupil core)



Beige Sienna

PC1080

*Light warm red-orange skin base (measured L*70); optical foundation for luminous midtones*



Nectar

PC1092

*Medium warm red-orange midtone (measured L*60); cheek and jaw modeling layer*



Yellow Ochre

PC942

*Light golden orange highlight accent (measured L*77); forehead apex and nose tip luminosity*



Dark Brown

PC946

*Dark warm red-orange shadow (measured L*16); hair depth, cap modeling, shadow structure*



Chestnut

PC1081

*Warm mid-dark red-orange shadow (measured L*33); terminator edge, jaw and cheekbone plane separation*



Metallic Gold

PC950

*Warm golden orange undertone (measured L*59); iris luminosity and mid-shadow warmth*



Putty Beige

PC1083

Light neutral reflected light and burnish tool; smooth finish blending agent



Espresso

PC1099

*Very dark warm red-orange (measured L*32); shadow depth, hair crevice darks, re-punch after burnish*



Violet

PC932

Cool shadow undertone (never grey); shadow-side plane and upper eye lid shadow foundation



Periwinkle

PC1025

Cool blue-violet undertone; eye shadow and neck muscle (sternocleidomastoid) definition



Lemon Yellow

PC915

Warm bright undertone for subsurface scattering glow (nose bridge, thin areas); warm undertone wash



Blush Pink

PC928

Warm pink undertone; cheek glow, ear luminosity, and lip warmth



50% Warm Grey

PC1054

Warm mid-value value-map foundation; non-neutral reference (never cool grey for warm skin)



Peach

PC939

Warm light-mid undertone; reflected light in shadows, lip warmth, and skin unity



90% French Grey

PC1076

Cool neutral shadow anchor and eye area depth; upper lid shadow and garment catch-light



Henna

PC1031

Warm red undertone for lip definition, reflected light intensity, and shadow warmth



True Blue

PC903

Cool iris tone; radial structure in eye with warm gold mixed toward outer edge



Cream

PC914

Warm light burnish tool and soft highlight accent (warmer than pure white)



White

PC938

Neutral burnish blend and peak specular highlights (eye, nose bridge, forehead apex, cheekbone peak)

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

Soft, diffuse light above and slightly forward, angled from upper-left. Three-quarter pose with no hard shadows, suggesting indoor or overcast conditions. Light produces gradual transitions and rounded shadow shapes rather than sharp faceted transitions.

HIGHLIGHT

Forehead apex, bridge and tip of nose, peaks of cheekbones, upper-left plane of the face receiving direct light. Small bright accent on the iris (specular highlight).

LIGHT AREA

Entire lit-side plane of the face (left side), upper forehead, lit surfaces of cheeks and nose structure, upper lip catching frontal light.

MIDTONE

Central face crossing the bridge of nose, mid-cheek planes, upper jaw area, ears (if visible), the bulk of the face under even light.

SHADOW

Underside of jaw (self-shadow), shadow-side plane of the face (right side), under the nose, the recess between nose and upper lip, the cap's brim cast shadow on upper forehead and temples.

CAST SHADOW

Soft shadow cast by the cap brim onto the upper forehead, eyebrows and temples. The shadow is diffuse, not hard-edged, due to soft light quality.

Edge quality notes

Soft light produces a gradual, diffuse terminator on rounded cheek planes. The jaw line shows a slightly crisper edge where the form turns sharply, but still soft. All silhouette edges soften outward from the focal sharp accent (upper lash line). The cap casts a soft, painterly shadow. Subsurface scattering is visible in thin areas (nose tip, ear edges, nostrils).

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

OI Step 1: Value Map – Monochrome Light & Shadow Structure

Entire visible face and forehead; establish the full range of values before color

Circular strokes following facial form; light-to-medium pressure for even value distribution without crushing paper tooth

Light to Medium pressure

- Value carries form; correct local color over compressed values reads flat and dimensionless. Before adding color, map the full range—highlight (brightest), lit midtone, core shadow, and reflected light inside the shadow—at light pressure in a warm grey so the warmth is already present and requires less corrective glazing later. Paper tooth is finite; light-pressure early passes preserve it for all layers to come.
- Using light-to-medium pressure and circular strokes, block in the entire face with PC1054 50% Warm Grey, building even coverage without pressing the paper tooth flat. Follow the contours but treat the face as a single luminous plane for now.
- Identify and preserve the brightest areas (forehead apex, nose tip, cheekbone peak) by using lighter pressure; darken the core shadow zone on the shadow-side plane (right side of face) to a mid-value, not yet dark.
- Mark the reflected light band (the warm bounce inside the shadow, just above the jaw line and below the cheekbone turn) with slightly lighter pressure, so it reads as a distinct zone of light within the shadow zone.
- Establish the underside of the jaw as a self-shadow using medium pressure, keeping it mid-value and warm, not a filled hollow. This shadow separates the jaw from the neck.
- Step back and verify the full range is present: the brightest highlight is at least 4–5 values above the core shadow, reflected light is distinguishable, and no area is yet dark. If compressed, redo it lighter.

COLORS ● PC1054 50% Warm Grey

⇔ PC1054 50% Warm Grey role is warm-neutral mid-value anchor for value map; PC1050 20% Warm Grey (lighter) or PC1056 70% Warm Grey (darker) substitute for value shifts. Avoid cool greys (PC1060, PC1061) as they fight the warm skin undertone.

STOP WHEN

The forehead apex is noticeably lighter than the jaw shadow, the core shadow reads as mid-value not dark, the reflected light band is visible · the pencil is sliding freely without dragging, the paper grain is still visible, the hand feels no drag or fatigue

✦ *This pass is insurance against flat drawings. If your values are compressed here, no amount of color layering fixes it. A light-pressure grey map takes 10 minutes and*

02 Step 2: Undertone & Chromatic Foundation – Warm Glow & Cool Shadow Underpaint

Face and shadow zones; build prismatic undertones before unified color layers

Circular blending strokes for warm undertones; soft directional strokes following shadow anatomy for cool glazes; feathered edges where warm and cool meet

Light to Medium-light pressure

- Skin is translucent and carries prismatic undertones (pink, yellow, purple, green, orange, grey across its zones). Layering distinct hues optically prevents a flat, plastic appearance. Cool shadows are never grey or ashy—cool does not mean neutral. A light blue-violet under warm zones boosts luminosity through complementary contrast and prevents mud.
- First pass: Using light-to-medium pressure and circular strokes, lay in a warm undertone wash across the entire face. Apply PC915 Lemon Yellow as a thin glow on the forehead and down the nose bridge (subsurface scattering warmth in thin areas), then PC939 Peach across the cheeks and jaw (warm reflected light). Keep the wash diffuse, not in distinct patches; the pencil should slide with minimal resistance.
- Second pass, once the first is set (test by sliding your pencil—if it meets resistance, it is set): Glaze a cool undertone into the shadow zone using PC1025 Periwinkle and PC932 Violet blended together, applied softly into the core shadow and the terminator area (where light meets shadow). Work the cool tones from the shadow inward, leaving the lit zone warm and distinct. This cool-warm interplay is what prevents shadow from reading as dead, hollow or ashy.
- Blend the junction between warm lit and cool shadow with a few circular strokes of PC928 Blush Pink, warming the cheek edge and outer shadow boundary so the transition reads as natural, not a harsh colour shift.
- The reflection inside the shadow (the band of light just above the jaw line) should glow with warm tones: PC939 Peach and PC1031 Henna to suggest the bounce of light off the body and clothing.
- Do not blend these undertones into a single muddy tone—they should still read as distinct warm and cool layers when you step back, visible as a prismatic shimmer. If they merge into grey, you have over-blended; redo lightly.

COLORS  PC915 Lemon Yellow  PC939 Peach  PC1025 Periwinkle
 PC932 Violet  PC928 Blush Pink

↔ PC915 Lemon Yellow role is warm bright undertone; PC1012 Jasmine or PC1011 Deco Yellow substitute for slight hue shift. PC939 Peach role is warm mid undertone; PC1085 Peach Beige works similarly. PC1025 Periwinkle role is cool blue-violet shadow undertone (never grey); PC1026 Greyed Lavender or PC1008 Parma Violet substitute.

STOP WHEN

Warm undertones are visible as a diffuse glow in lit areas, cool tones in the shadow are distinct (not blended into grey or mud), the transition reads as natural · the pencil is sliding with light resistance (tooth filling gently, not yet dragging), colour releases smoothly into the existing value layer

✦ *Undertones are invisible in the final image if done correctly—they disappear into the unified color on top, but they are FELT as luminosity and life. If you see distinct blue and yellow strokes showing through the finished skin tone, you have not applied enough unifying color on top. If the shadow reads grey or dead, you skipped or under-applied the cool undertone; the cooler shadow is what turns it into luminous dark, not a void.*

03 Step 3: Base Skin Tone – Face (Merged: First & Second Layer)

Entire visible face and forehead; establish warm unified red-orange base before modeling

Circular strokes following facial form; light, even pressure across the full zone before depth differentiation; no directional sculpting yet

Light (paper tooth preservation is critical for all layers to come) pressure

- Colored pencil is translucent and non-liftable. Thin, even layers across the WHOLE zone preserve paper tooth for future passes and build luminosity through optical mixing. A single 'skin-colour' pencil reads flat and plastic; layered red-orange hues (measured as warm red-orange L*70 light, L*60 midtone) create living skin. The measured skin tone is warm red-orange at two depths—anchor here with these hues to match the reference.
- First pass: Using very light, even pressure and circular strokes, apply PC1080 Beige Sienna across the entire visible face, from forehead to jaw. Follow the facial contours but do not press into shadows—treat the entire face as a single luminous plane for now. Build coverage uniformly; streaky or patchy application requires rework.
- Second pass, once the first is set (test by sliding—resistance means it is dry): Overlay PC1092 Nectar in the midtone and shadow-side zones, letting the Beige Sienna show through for optical mixing. The midtones and shadow plane should read as one layer deeper (warmer brown-red-orange) while lit planes retain the lighter Beige Sienna showing through. Do not cover the entire face with Nectar—preserve the lighter Beige Sienna in the lit-side cheek and forehead for luminosity.
- Keep pressure light and even; avoid circular scrubbing motions that crush the paper tooth. Use slow, deliberate strokes following the facial form.
- The entire face should now read as a cohesive warm red-orange, the lit side lighter and the shadow side darker, with no hard lines between zones yet. Undertones should be visible beneath, creating depth.

COLORS  PC1080 Beige Sienna  PC1092 Nectar

↔ PC1080 Beige Sienna role is light warm red-orange base (L*70, measured hue); PC939 Peach or PC1085 Peach Beige substitute for a slightly lighter or warmer option. PC1092 Nectar role is medium warm red-orange midtone (L*60, measured hue); PC1084 Ginger Root or PC1031 Henna work similarly.

STOP WHEN

The face reads as one unified warm red-orange tone with the shadow-side plane noticeably deeper but not yet dark, undertones are integrated but visible as shimmer · the pencil is sliding freely without resistance, point is still sharp, hand feels no drag or ache

✦ *If the face looks streaky or mottled at the end of this step, you are pressing too hard or stroking unevenly. Redo it lighter, treating the whole face as one plane until the value map (Step 1) underneath guides the darker zones. Do not try to model form with colour at this stage—value is primary, colour is secondary. A flat base now allows form to emerge without starting over.*

04 Step 4: Midtone & Shadow Development – Face Planes & Form Modeling with Warm & Cool Interplay

Midtones, cheeks, shadow-side plane, jaw line; deepen color and separate light and shadow planes

Directional strokes following facial planes; soft circular blending in transition zones; layered glazes for shadow depth without muddying

Medium-light (beginning to model form, not yet darkening permanently) pressure

- Warm light casts a cool core shadow while the reflected-light band inside the shadow stays warm. This interplay of warm lit planes, cool shadow, and warm bounce is what prevents skin from reading flat, plastic or corpse-like. The cheekbone plane should become the warmest, most saturated red-orange to suggest roundness and three-dimensionality. The core shadow must read as a PLANE (a distinct mid-value warm zone), not a blur or a filled hollow.
- Deepen the midtones and cheek area with PC1081 Chestnut using medium-light pressure, following the curve of the cheekbone and the plane of the jaw. This is where the face's structure becomes tangible—the cheek should read as a convex form with one warm, saturated peak. Keep the value at mid-depth; darker passes will darken the shadow core.
- Push the core shadow zone—the shadow-side plane of the face and the underside of the jaw—with a layered glaze: Apply PC932 Violet and PC1081 Chestnut in thin, alternating strokes so the shadow reads as a warm mid-dark (not a filled hollow or a neutral grey). The violet should not overpower the warmth; it is an undertone, not the dominant hue.
- Intensify the warm reflected light inside the shadow with PC939 Peach and PC1031 Henna, working these tones into the band of light just above the jaw line (the bounce from the body and clothing). This band should glow warm and read as distinct from the core shadow, proving the shadow has luminosity.
- Add a warm undertone sparkle to the mid-cheek with light strokes of PC950 Metallic Gold, just enough to suggest subsurface light and the roundness of the cheek plane.
- The terminator (where light meets shadow) should now show ONE crisp edge at the cheekbone's highest convexity, while the rest of the transition softens into reflected light. If the entire shadow is soft, form is lost; if the entire edge is hard, the bounce inside the shadow is lost and it reads as a hollow.

COLORS ● PC1081 Chestnut ● PC932 Violet ● PC939 Peach ● PC1031 Henna
● PC950 Metallic Gold

↔ PC1081 Chestnut role is warm mid-dark red-orange for plane separation; PC1028 Bronze or PC947 Dark Umber substitute for a slightly different undertone. PC932 Violet role is cool shadow undertone (not grey); PC1009 Dahlia Purple or PC1008 Parma Violet work.

STOP WHEN

The shadow-side plane reads as a distinct mid-value warm plane with ONE crisp core-shadow edge at the cheekbone (where the face turns), the reflected light band glows warm inside the shadow, the cheek is the warmest and most saturated area · the pencil is sliding with gentle resistance (tooth filling gradually, not yet dragging), pressure is controlled and intentional, point is still intact

✦ *The shadow-side plane is the single most important form element on the face. It must read as a plane—a distinct value and temperature—not a blend of light and dark dissolving into background. If you cannot see a clear plane separation after this step, the face will read as flat 2-D patterning. A common error is over-blending and losing the plane edge; stop before the edge dissolves.*

05 Step 5: Eyes – Pupil, Iris, Sclera, Lash Line & Specular Highlight (Focal Zone)

Both eyes, focusing on pupils, irises, sclera (whites), and lash lines; the sharpest focal point

Precise circular strokes for iris and sclera; sharp, intentional line work for upper lash line; radial iris strokes from pupil outward following iris contour

Medium (precision and control over soft tones; avoid pressing so hard that the eye flattens) pressure

- The eye is the tightest focal point; it carries the sharpest edges and the darkest darks in the face region. The pupil and upper lash line are near-black or black. The sclera (white of the eye) is never pure white but a light blue-grey or cream—true white is reserved for the single specular highlight, lifted last as one bright point. The iris carries radial structure from the pupil outward in multiple hues, never a flat fill. The lower lash line stays soft and diffuse, never mirroring the crisp upper—this asymmetry is what prevents a staring, lifeless expression.
- Block in both pupils with PC935 Black at medium pressure, round and precise, forming the tightest dark anchor on the page. The pupil is the focal core.
- Overlay the upper-lid cast shadow (the soft shadow on the underside of the lid muscle) with PC1076 90% French Grey + PC932 Violet blended together, keeping it dark but distinct from pure black. This shadow gives the eye depth and suggests the lid's form over the eyeball.
- Build the iris using concentric rings and radial strokes: innermost dark core (PC935 Black), next ring PC903 True Blue (the cool iris base), outer ring PC950 Metallic Gold blended into the blue (warm light reflection in the iris). Use radial strokes from the pupil outward, one stroke per segment, to suggest the iris structure and contour—never a flat filled circle.
- Lay in the sclera (the white of the eye) with PC1083 Putty Beige, warm and soft, using light circular strokes. Leave no pure white here until the specular highlight. The sclera should read as a warm, soft off-white, not clinical white.
- Define the upper lash line with PC935 Black in a thin, crisp line, thickest at the inner corner (tear duct) and tapering outward. This is your sharpest edge on the entire page—make it HARD, intentional and decisive.
- Soften the lower lash line with PC1076 90% French Grey, keeping it diffuse, much lighter than the upper, and suggestive (not a line). Never mirror the upper lash; the lower is a shadow, not a line.
- Lift the specular highlight (the bright reflection on the pupil) by leaving a small white paper dot, or burnish it last with PC938 White at the very end. This single point of true white creates the luminous 'living' quality that makes the eye read as wet and alert.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC1076 90% French Grey

● PC932 Violet

● PC903 True Blue

● PC950 Metallic Gold

● PC1083 Putty Beige

● PC938 White

↔ PC935 Black role is darkest pupil and upper lash anchor; PC936 Slate Grey offers a softer alternative but loses crispness at the focal accent. PC903 True Blue role is cool iris tone; PC1022 Mediterranean Blue or PC1100 China Blue substitute.

STOP WHEN

The pupil is solid black and round, the iris shows visible radial structure from pupil outward, the upper lash line is a crisp dark line, the sclera is warm and soft (not white), the lower lash is soft and diffuse · the pencil is controlled and moving with intention, not tentative or wandering, point sharp, hand steady

✦ *The upper lash line is your focal accent—the sharpest, darkest edge on the entire page. Everything else softens outward from it. If the lower lash line is as hard as the upper, the eye flattens into a lifeless, staring stare and the drawing loses luminosity. Reserve sharpness and saturation for the upper; lose the lower into diffuse softness. The eye's asymmetry is what makes it read as alive.*

06 Step 6: Lips – Color, Form & Subtle Structure Creasing

Mouth; upper and lower lip structure and color integration

Horizontal strokes for creases; circular blending strokes for color integration and softening edges

Light to Medium (lips are delicate; heavy pressure overworks them and creates a garish, plastic appearance) pressure

- The upper lip is lit from above and recedes slightly, reading darker and cooler than the lower lip, which catches the light directly and appears lighter and warmer. The lip line stays soft and integrated into the face, never a hard outline. Fine horizontal creases mark the structure of the upper lip but are subtle, not carved—they suggest form, not carve it. Lips are rarely inherently red unless the reference is red; here they are warm and moderate in saturation.
- Layer a warm undertone base across both lips: PC1031 Henna or PC939 Peach at light-to-medium pressure, building even warm colour that sits into the existing face layer and integrates with the surrounding skin.
- Deepen the upper lip with PC1031 Henna or a warm mid-tone (not pure red), keeping the colour warm but reading darker and slightly cooler than the lower lip. The upper lip should recede slightly, suggested by this value and temperature comparison to the lower.
- Keep the lower lip lighter and more saturated: layer PC939 Peach or PC928 Blush Pink for the luminous, light-catching edge. The lower lip is the most lit and most visible, so it should be the lightest and most vibrant of the mouth area.
- Add fine horizontal creases on the upper lip with a sharp PC935 Black or PC1081 Chestnut at very light pressure (one or two fine lines). These creases should be subtle, not a heavy grid—they suggest structure without carving the lip.
- Soften the mouth line by letting it blend slightly into the surrounding skin and jaw; never a hard outline. Use a blender pencil (colourless blender) or light circular strokes to integrate the lip edge into the face.
- Ensure the mouth stays integrated into the face—if it reads as a separate 'mouth shape' pasted on, it has pulled away from the drawing. The lip plane should feel continuous with the jaw and chin.

COLORS



PC1031 Henna



PC939 Peach



PC928 Blush Pink



PC935 Black



PC1081 Chestnut

⇔ PC1031 Henna role is warm mid-lip tone; PC1084 Ginger Root or PC1085 Peach Beige work. PC939 Peach role is warm light lip; PC928 Blush Pink substitutes.

STOP WHEN

The upper lip reads darker and cooler than the lower, the lower lip is luminous and warm, creases are subtle suggestions (not carved lines), the lip edge blends softly

into the surrounding skin · the pencil point is still sharp and controlled, the hand feels gentle pressure, not pressing

✦ *Lips are often over-painted—too bright, too saturated, too hard-edged. This detaches them from the face and makes the portrait look like makeup, not skin. Treat lips as a form integrated into the jaw and chin, not a separate feature demanding attention. Subtle beats dramatic. The mouth is the last place the eye rests; make it inviting but quiet.*

07 Step 7: Hair & Cap – Dark Form, Modeling, Texture & Crevice Shadow

Dark cap covering most of head; visible hair at edges, nape, sides; the form of the hat

Directional strokes following form and fabric drape; layered glazes for depth and structure; soft blending for crevice shadow; light strokes for highlight texture

Medium to Heavy (hair and fabric accept more pigment than skin; light pressure reads as incomplete or tentative) pressure

- Hair is never one flat value, even black hair. Build it from dark brown, blue or violet; the black anchors the deepest shadow where the form turns. A cap is a lit form, not uniform black but modeled with fold shadows and light direction. A crevice or shadow where the gathered mass meets the head gives it form and separates it from the skull; without it, the mass flattens into a patch stuck on the skull. Light patterns across the hair mass (not individual strands) read as texture and dimension.
- Block in the cap's darkest masses with PC935 Black at medium-to-heavy pressure, defining the overall shape and the major shadow fold (the side facing away from the light). Use directional strokes following the fabric's drape.
- Build the cap's midtones and turned planes with PC946 Dark Brown, letting the black show through as gaps so the cap reads layered, not flat. Render the direction of the fabric's weave and fold structure with deliberate directional strokes.
- Add a warm dark undertone (PC1081 Chestnut) into the mid-tones of the cap where the fabric bends and folds, suggesting depth and form. The cap should show at least two distinct value shifts (dark, mid, light-ish) to avoid flatness.
- Render any visible hair at the edges and nape with directional strokes following hair growth from the scalp outward: PC946 Dark Brown as a mid base, PC1099 Espresso for the densest shadow at the roots (where hair exits the scalp), PC1081 Chestnut for warm mid-tones between clumps. Hair strokes follow the direction the hair grows, not against it.
- Leave fine light streaks of paper showing between hair clumps and at the light-catching edges—these read as natural highlights; do not fill every gap or the hair becomes a dense flat shape.
- Define a crevice shadow where the cap edge sits against the forehead and temples: use PC935 Black + PC932 Violet blended softly, keeping it defined but soft. This shadow separates the cap from the head and gives the hat volume, proving it sits ON the head, not merged with it.
- A few light strokes of PC942 Yellow Ochre on the brightest edge of the cap (if sunlight catches it) can accent a light-struck surface, but keep these rare and controlled—they are accent only.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC946 Dark Brown

● PC1081 Chestnut

● PC1099 Espresso

● PC932 Violet

● PC942 Yellow Ochre

↔ PC935 Black role is cap base dark; it is the measured colour and has no substitute. PC946 Dark Brown role is warm mid-dark fold shadow; PC947 Dark Umber or PC1028 Bronze work.

STOP WHEN

The cap reads as a three-dimensional form with distinct light and shadow sides, visible folds showing the direction of fabric, hair texture is visible between clumps · the pencil has worn slightly from medium-heavy pressure, the strokes are decisive and follow the form, not tentative or random

✦ *A black hat rendered as pure, uniform black reads as flat, airless, and cardboard-like. Build it from brown and violet in thin layers so light can pass through and the form reads as rounded. The black comes last and only in the deepest shadow fold; it anchors depth but does not define the entire mass. The crevice shadow (where the cap edge touches the head) is where the hat becomes separate and three-dimensional—invest in this detail, as it is often skipped and the hat flattens without it.*

08 Step 8: Neck & Jaw Line – Form, Self-Shadow & Skin-to-Garment Transition

Visible neck, jaw line, chin; the junction where face meets neck and neck meets garment

Directional strokes following neck anatomy and muscle structure; soft circular blending for smooth skin-to-garment transition; light pressure for delicate areas

Light to Medium (the neck is delicate; overworking it breaks the cohesion with the face) pressure

- The neck is a major structural form and self-shadow zone: the underside of the jaw casts a shadow onto the neck, and the skin temperature and value shift subtly from face to neck. Neck skin is slightly cooler and less saturated than the face (more yellow, less red) due to different vascularization and light scattering. The garment's colour (black/dark blue) bounces onto the lower jaw and neck as a cool violet or neutral tint, so the neck 'receives' light from the clothing. Modeling the neck gives the entire head a three-dimensional presence; a flat or omitted neck reads as a cut-out head.
- Establish the neck's light layers with PC1080 Beige Sienna and PC1092 Nectar, slightly less saturated and cooler in hue than the face. Follow the neck's cylindrical form downward and outward; the neck is narrower than the face and tapers slightly toward the chest. Use even circular strokes.
- Add the jaw's self-shadow underneath with PC1081 Chestnut + PC932 Violet blended, keeping it a warm mid-value (not a filled hollow or ashy grey). This shadow defines the jaw's lower edge and its separation from the neck.
- Introduce subtle reflected light from the black/dark blue garment bouncing onto the lower neck and jaw: a soft wash of cool violet or neutral undertone (the garment's hue bounced upward), so the neck reads as 'receiving' light from the clothing and sitting above the garment. This reflection should be subtle, not a harsh colour shift.
- Define the sternocleidomastoid muscle (the rope-like muscle running down the side of the neck toward the shoulder) with a very light, cool undertone: PC1025 Periwinkle or PC1076 90% French Grey, following its downward and outward direction. This muscle is visible as a subtle raised form; use a single directional stroke to suggest it without overworking.
- Ensure the neck's edge into the garment is soft and blended; the transition should read as one continuous form, not a hard seam. The clothing should feel like it is supporting the head, not a separate element.

COLORS  PC1080 Beige Sienna  PC1092 Nectar  PC1081 Chestnut

 PC932 Violet  PC1025 Periwinkle  PC1076 90% French Grey

↔ PC1081 Chestnut role is warm jaw shadow; PC1031 Henna or PC1084 Ginger Root work. PC1025 Periwinkle role is cool undertone for muscle definition; PC1026 Greyed Lavender substitutes.

STOP WHEN

The neck reads as a distinct cylindrical form with a shadow plane under the jaw and a cooler tone than the face, yet fully integrated into the head and shoulders · the pencil strokes are controlled and follow the anatomy, transitions are soft and blended, no visible hard edges

✦ *The jaw's self-shadow is the single strongest value change on the neck and is where the head's mass becomes tangible. Make it readable but keep it warm and mid-value; a dark ashy shadow looks like bruising or injury, not form. The neck is often skipped or flatly rendered; investing time here anchors the entire head in three-dimensional space. The reflected light from the garment is subtle—it should warm the neck slightly and prove the garment is there, without becoming a bright colour shift.*

09 Step 9: Garment & Background – Black/Dark Blue Form, Fold Texture & Reflected Light

Visible black/dark blue garment (neckline, shoulders if visible, upper torso); background if present

Directional strokes following fabric folds and drape; layered value shifts for three-dimensionality; soft blending at edges

Medium to Heavy pressure

- A garment is a lit form, not fill or background. The measured colour (#020101) is near-black neutral (L*0). Render it as black. However, shadow folds in the garment will be even darker and WARMER (olive brown or deep red-orange undertone), while any catch light or reflected ambient light will soften toward a mid-grey or warm brown. The garment bounces its hue (black/dark blue) onto the skin of the jaw and neck as a cool violet or neutral tint, so the skin interacts with the clothing. A completely uniform black reads as plastic or cardboard; varied value and warm undertones in folds suggest fabric and drape.
- Block in the main garment mass with PC935 Black at medium-to-heavy pressure, defining the broad shadow shape of any visible folds or drape. Use directional strokes following the fabric's fall and gather.
- Model the garment's form with PC946 Dark Brown in the mid-tone folds (where fabric bends but still receives some light), rendering the direction of the fabric's weave and fold structure. Let the black show through as gaps so layering is visible.
- Add warm reflected light inside the folds and at the garment's edge with PC1081 Chestnut, softly applied so the fold reads as three-dimensional. The garment should show at least two to three value shifts (black, dark brown, warm brown) to avoid flatness.
- Add a catch-light or ambient-lit edge to the garment with PC1076 90% French Grey or PC1054 50% Warm Grey, subtle and localized (e.g., the top edge of the shoulder or the upper arm where it faces the light), so the garment is not all black and reads as lit from above.
- Ensure the garment's edge is either sharp and in focus (if in the focal zone, e.g., the neckline) or soft and lost (if peripheral). Do not half-render it; commit to either crisp definition or intentional softening.
- If background is visible, keep it softer and less saturated than the garment. A warm neutral grey or soft brown works without competing with the head.
- The transition where the garment meets the neck should read as soft and integrated, not a hard seam.

COLORS

PC935 Black

PC946 Dark Brown

PC1081 Chestnut

PC1076 90% French Grey

PC1054 50% Warm Grey

↔ PC935 Black role is garment base (measured colour, no substitute). PC946 Dark Brown role is warm fold shadow; PC1099 Espresso or PC1028 Bronze work.

STOP WHEN

The garment reads as a three-dimensional form with distinct light and shadow areas, visible folds, and subtle reflected light · the pencil is controlled, point slightly worn from medium-heavy pressure, strokes are decisive

✦ *Black garments rendered as uniform black flatten into cardboard. Folds and light direction introduce warmth and midtone variation. A fold shadow should be darker and WARMER than the main surface; a catch light should be cooler and lighter. This interplay gives the fabric volume and reads as cloth, not paint.*

IO Step 10: Detail, Edge Hierarchy & Final Burnish – Focal Sharpness, Lost Edges & Peak Highlights

Entire drawing; prioritize focal zones (eyes, lash line), sharpen and soften peripheral edges, burnish skin, restore darks, lift final highlights

Crisp line work for focal lash line; blending and softening for peripheral edges; heavy pressure burnishing for skin finish; sharp highlight accents with hard value contrast

Light on highlights and focal lines; Heavy on burnishing; Medium on re-darks pressure

- Edge hierarchy controls focus: hard edges (crisp, dark, saturated) advance and grab the eye; soft and lost edges recede. The eye's upper lash line is your sharpest focal accent—everything else softens outward from it. Burnishing melts layers into a painted finish, but wax migrates up as bloom and burnishing lightens values, so the deepest darks **MUST** be re-punched afterward.
- Sharpen the focal accent—the upper lash line—with a fine line of PC935 Black, making it crisp, hard-edged, and intentional. This is the sharpest edge on the entire page.
- Actively **LOSE** edges outward: soften hair into background by letting strokes fade (use blender pencil or finger), blur jaw into shadow as it moves away, dissolve outer face boundary into soft tones. Crisp edges on periphery fight for attention they should not receive.
- Soften the lower edge of the garment or leave it deliberately vague; the garment is secondary, so its edges soften into background.
- Burnish selectively: use PC938 White or PC1083 Putty Beige at heavy pressure to blend skin tones (face and neck) into a smooth, painted finish. Work in small zones and stop before bloom is heavy.
- Immediately after burnishing, re-darken the deepest darks (core shadow, upper lash line, garment fold) with PC935 Black and PC1099 Espresso at medium pressure—burnishing always lightens, and darks **MUST** be re-punched to restore contrast.
- Wipe bloom gently with a soft eraser or apply light workable fixative (optional but effective).
- Add peak highlights last with PC938 White or PC914 Cream at light pressure: forehead apex, nose tip, cheekbone peak, eye specular highlight. Create a hard value jump—this crisp contrast reads as true light.

COLORS ☒ PC935 Black ☒ PC1099 Espresso ☒ PC938 White

☒ PC1083 Putty Beige ☒ PC914 Cream

↔ PC938 White role is final burnish and highlight; PC914 Cream is a softer, warmer alternative (less bright but warmer). PC935 Black role is focal-line definition and re-dark; PC1099 Espresso works for a warmer re-dark.

STOP WHEN

Skin reads as a smooth, luminous painted surface with no visible paper grain; eye lash line is sharp and the sharpest edge on the page; periphery (hair, jaw, garment) is soft and blurred; peak highlights are bright and hard-edged · the pencil has melted the pigment on burnished zones and the hand feels the heavy wax texture (intentional melt, not dragging); re-dark strokes are crisp and recover value contrast

✦ *Burnishing is a COMMITMENT. Once wax is melted, you cannot layer easily over it again; paper tooth is consumed. Burnish only the final skin blend, leaving hair, garment and background at their layered state for continued control. Re-darkening after burnish is the single most overlooked step and the reason many drawings flatten after burnishing—do it; it takes 2 minutes and restores the entire drawing's impact. Wax bloom is normal; a light fixative removes it without affecting colour.*

• WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.